



states **MAHARASHTRA**

PLAYING CATCH-UP

As Raj Thackeray's divisive politics in the name of Marathi *manoos* strikes a chord among the locals, mainline political parties join the fray with sops and an eye on the forthcoming elections

■ By Aditi Pai

It is not known if Raj Thackeray read Sun Tsu as a young man but he seems to have borrowed a thing or two from the ancient Chinese General's war tactics. In trying to revive his political career, he has adopted a strategy that's a virtual "Heads I win, tails you lose" challenge to Maharashtra's mainline political parties who can neither be seen as opposing his stand nor can they afford to let him walk away as the messiah of the Marathi *manoos*.

Two years after floating the party, Raj had almost disappeared from the political firmament. That was until about two months ago when he launched a tirade against north Indian migrants, only to endear himself to locals. Thanks to him, Maharashtra has a new hero. After years of neglect by almost all political parties, Marathi votebank has sud-

denly become all-important for all parties. If Gujarati *asmita* yielded rich dividends for Narendra Modi, political parties in Maharashtra have found a new cause that has caught the imagination of the Maharashtrian

BHASKAR PAUL



Let the government arrest me if it wants. I maintain that only Maharashtra Day should be celebrated here.

masses. While Raj's outburst may have been against immigrants, he has raised the ante and made the neglect of Marathis an issue. Not surprisingly, the Shiv Sena is in a mad rush to please the Marathi votebank—which accounts for 64 per cent of the state's electorate. While his former party, the Sena, is trying to recapture its original Marathi agenda, the Congress and Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) are jumping on to the bandwagon to do their bit for the Marathis with promises of reservation in jobs. "Everyone, including the 'secular' parties wants to be seen as the saviour of the Marathis. We are happy that they are taking up our age-old cause," says Sena spokesperson Sanjay Raut.

When Raj stepped out of his mentor-uncle's party in December 2005, political observers dismissed him as an errant child who would eventually come back to the Tiger's fold. But two years after he formed his